

The decision broke Bud. Not only was he judged to be guilty of defrauding investors, but his license to sell securities was suspended for five years. He was penniless and without the means to earn a living.

The judge allowed the plaintiffs to attach anything of value Bud owned now or in the future. They elected to force Bud into bankruptcy by notifying all of his outstanding creditors that they intended to attach and sell any and all properties he owned, including his house. Bud's other creditors quickly filed suit, trying to get at least some part of Bud's assets.

"Bud, you told me this lawsuit would amount to nothing, and now we have this judgment against us," Sandi said angrily. "Do you call this nothing?"

"Look, I told you I'm sorry." Bud sighed. "I wanted to tell you, but I just didn't know how. They're demanding a forced sale of the house and everything else. We'll be wiped out. I wouldn't blame you if you decided to leave. The SEC is suspending my license for five years because I lost the lawsuit; I won't even have a way to earn a living."

"Bud, I don't care about this house or the investments. I told you that before. I just want to be a part of your life. I will stick by you because we promised God that our marriage is for better or worse. I love you, and we'll be able to see this thing through together," Sandi said earnestly. The tears welled up in her eyes. "I was afraid you were going down the same path I saw my own father go down before he left my mother, and it frightened me."

"I'm so sorry, Sandi," Bud said as he put his arms around her. "I didn't know that's what you were thinking. I thought I was doing all these deals for you and the kids. Now I realize that I was doing them to feed my own ego and insecurity. I feared going back to always struggling, so much that I was willing to throw away the most important assets God ever gave me."

"Bud, we've drifted so far from God's path. I want to rededicate our lives to serving Him—like we promised to do in college."